

Intentional Friction

What is it?

Adding small, purposeful obstacles in a flow to slow users down just enough to prevent mistakes or rushed decisions.

History

Recognized in UX practice and behavioral design discussions around **2014**, when teams began intentionally adding small pauses or confirmations to reduce errors and increase thoughtful decision-making.

The Psychology Behind It

- People make poor decisions when rushing
- A tiny pause increases attention
- Encourages reflective thinking
- Reduces accidental or impulsive actions

Why It Matters

- Better engagement
- Higher conversions
- Improved decision quality
- Reduced user errors

How to Apply It

- Confirmation dialogs
- “Type to confirm” steps for irreversible actions
- Smart reminders for missing info
- Deliberate speed bumps in critical flows

Theory in Action

- Mailchimp requires typing a specific command before deleting data
- Gmail warns users when they send an email without attaching files after mentioning “attachment”

Final Thought

A little friction can protect users from harmful mistakes. Good friction feels intentional and helpful — not annoying or burdensome.